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INDO-PACIFIC ... THROUGH THE PRISMS OF USA & INDIA

UPSC CSE – GS II

International Relations



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The geopolitics of Indo-Pacific: how India and others interpret the term

NIJUPAMA SUBRAMANIAN
MUMBAI, JUNE 30

THE TERM "Indo-Pacific" has featured during the past week's G20 summit as well as during US Secretary of State Mike Pompeo's recent visit to Delhi. Geographically, the Indo-Pacific refers to the Indian and Pacific Oceans between the east coast of Africa and the Americas west coast and their several littoral countries. As a region to develop an economic and strategic community, it has been an unambiguous focus of international relations and geopolitics since the first decade of this century, around the same time as China's rise. The conflict it was centred upon in a paper written by Georgetown University, an Indian naval officer, on the convergence between Japanese and Indian strategic interests in protecting sea routes for energy security. On a visit to India in 2007, Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe did not use the word "Indo-Pacific" but a "freedom of the seas" in the "Confidence of Two Seas".

"The Pacific and the Indian Oceans are now being defined as a single body of water of freedom and prosperity. A freedom that links away geographic boundaries to new beginning for a new world order. The two oceans have the ability – and the responsibility – to ensure that this freedom be further solidified and

and stretch these seas to become seas of shared destiny," he said then.

Gaining currency

It was an Australian paper envisaging its security and trade policy through a new region in 2011-2012, the Indo-Pacific. It was its way to position itself to play a larger role in Asia, as an ally of the US and Japan, and as a country with friendly ties with China, India, Indonesia and South Korea among others. At the end of 2012, the Julia Gillard government brought out a White Paper on "Australia and the Asian Century". Following it with a national security policy document, "Strong and Secure – A Strategy for Australia's National Interest" at the beginning of 2013, both documents articulated Australia's Indo-Pacific. This is what the White Paper had to say about it: "Over the past decade, we have used the term 'Indo-Pacific' to describe the Asian region. Under such a description, the western Pacific Ocean and the Indian Ocean would come to be considered one strategic area. This description is consistent with the historical economic interaction between South, Southeast and Southwest Asia and the importance of the lines of energy supply to Asia from the Middle East."

Through Australia continued the term which he initially, its widespread use in international diplomacy came from a speech after an October 2017 speech by US India relations by former US Secretary of State



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar with visiting US Secretary of State Mike Pompeo in Delhi June 28. Jaishankar said the point for made was that the Indo-Pacific is "for something, not against somebody". (AP)

Mike Tillerson, who spoke of a partnership between the two countries in the interests of a "free and open Indo-Pacific". He spoke of India as more influential than China. "The Pacific and the Indian Oceans are now being defined as a single body of water of freedom and prosperity. A freedom that links away geographic boundaries to new beginning for a new world order. The two oceans have the ability – and the responsibility – to ensure that this freedom be further solidified and

very much off the China-Pakistan economic corridor, running through Pakistan, through Gwadar, and even generally over the Indian Ocean and the Red Sea region."

By the very name, Indo-Pacific was being used more frequently by the Trump Administration, already replacing the term "Asia-Pacific", which was replaced by analysts from Oxford and Johns Hopkins and Cambridge as reflecting the region away from China's economic and strategic dominance. Already in the US National Security

Strategy of 2017, the Indo-Pacific had been described as a region where "geopolitical competition between free and repressive systems of world order is taking place" – China and North Korea on one side and all others on the other.

Continue India

The move away from Asia-Pacific also seemed to elevate India to a position of prominence in the region, as a US ally that would help to contain China's dominance. Towards that end, the adoption of the term also appeared to challenge India to play a larger role in the region, for instance in the Quad, or the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue that informally brings together for strategic talks and military exercises, the US, Japan, Australia and India.

But India, quite aware of the internal dangers of protecting in the region, has sought to bring its own economic definition of Indo-Pacific.

In June 2018, at the Shangri-La Dialogue in Singapore, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said: "The Indo-Pacific is a construct, not a region. It is a vision of a great array of global opportunities and challenges... The two most important South-East Asian countries in both the geographical and civilizational sense, Indonesia, Malaysia, and ASEAN, are all in Indo-Pacific. India is a naturally free with Indo-Pacific. India does not use the Indo-Pacific Region as a strategy or as a club of limited members.

It is a grouping that seeks to dominate Asia by no means do we consider it as directed against any country. A geographical definition, as such, cannot be India's vision for the Indo-Pacific Region is, therefore, a positive one."

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar's statement, during US Secretary of State Mike Pompeo's visit to Delhi earlier this week captured some of that vision.

"The Indo-Pacific Region – the big picture – is made up of the Indo-Pacific is for something, not against somebody. And that something is peace, security, stability, prosperity and order," Jaishankar said in his opening remarks at the joint press meet with Pompeo in New Delhi Wednesday.

It is unclear if India and US are on the same page on the definition of the Indo-Pacific. In the last US National Security Strategy document, in 2017 the Indo-Pacific is described as the region from the "west coast of India to the west coast of the United States". However, India looks at a wider region, which extends all the way to West Asia and the east coast of Africa. For India, important as ensuring the west, is its southern maritime security where the Indian Ocean and Indian Sea meet – only then the freedom with Pakistan, India's energy security are all in mind. Asia, where India is heavily tied with US, has been the focus of the US Indo-Pacific strategy in a recent engagement with the Indian Ocean Rim Association countries.

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests, Indian diaspora.

DRAFT QUESTION

Discuss the fundamental differences on how India and USA views "Indo-Pacific Construct".

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56 The geopolitics of Indo-Pacific

How India and others interpret the term

As a term to denote an economic and strategic community, it has been in use among scholars of international relations and geopolitics since the first decade of this century, around the same time as China's rise.

The term “Indo-Pacific” has featured during the just-concluded G20 summit as well as during US Secretary of State Michael Pompeo’s recent visit to Delhi. Geographically, the Indo-Pacific refers to the Indian and the Pacific Oceans between the east coast of Africa and the American west coast and their several littoral countries. As a term to denote an economic and strategic community, it has been in use among scholars of international relations and geopolitics since the first decade of this century, around the same time as China’s rise. The earliest it was noticed was in a paper written by Gurpreet Khurana, an Indian naval officer, on the congruence between Japanese and Indian strategic interests in protecting sea routes for energy security. On a visit to India in 2007, Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe did not use the exact term, but spoke of a “broader Asia” in the “Confluence of Two Seas”.

“The Pacific and the Indian Oceans are now bringing about a dynamic coupling as seas of freedom and of prosperity. A ‘broader Asia’ that broke away geographical boundaries is now beginning to take on a distinct form. Our two countries have the ability — and the responsibility — to ensure that it broadens yet further and to nurture and enrich these seas to become seas of clearest transparency,” Abe said then.

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Gaining currency

It was as Australia began reimagining its security and trade policies through a new regional lens in 2011-2012, that Indo-Pacific became its way to position itself to play a larger role in Asia, as an ally of the US and Japan, and as a country with friendly ties with China, India, Indonesia and South Korea among others. At the end of 2012, the Julia Gillard government brought out a White Paper on 'Australia and the Asian century', following it with a national security policy document, 'Strong and Secure – A Strategy for Australia's National Interest' at the beginning of 2013. Both dealt in detail with the term Indo-Pacific. This is what the White Paper had to say about it: "Some observers have raised a new 'Indo-Pacific' conception of the Asian region. Under such a conception, the western Pacific Ocean and the Indian Ocean would come to be considered as one strategic arc. This conception is being driven by the increased economic interaction between South, Northeast and Southeast Asia and the importance of the lines of energy supply to Asia from the Middle East."

Though Australia embraced the term wholeheartedly, its widespread use in international diplomacy came five years later, after an October 2017 speech on US-India relations by former US Secretary of State Rex Tillerson, who spoke of a partnership between the two countries in the interests of a "free and open Indo-Pacific". He spoke of India as more reliable than China: "We need to collaborate with India to ensure that the Indo-Pacific is increasingly a place of peace, stability, and growing prosperity— so that it does not become a region of disorder, conflict, and predatory economics."

56 The geopolitics of Indo-Pacific

India lavished praise on the speech, delivered at the height of the Delhi-Beijing tensions over several issues – the Doklam military standoff, the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor running through Pakistan-Occupied Kashmir, and more generally over the entire Chinese Belt and Road Initiative.

By the next year, Indo-Pacific was being used more frequently by the Trump Administration, entirely replacing the earlier “Asia-Pacific”, a move recognised by analysts from Delhi and Beijing to Tokyo and Canberra as redefining the region away from China’s economic and strategic dominance.

Already in the US National Security Strategy of 2017, the Indo-Pacific had been described as a region where “geopolitical competition between free and repressive visions of world order is taking place” – China and North Korea on one side and all others on the other.

Cautious India

The move away from Asia-Pacific also seemed to elevate India to a position of prominence in the region, as a US ally that would help to contain China’s dominance. Towards this end, the adoption of the term also appeared to challenge India to play a larger role in the region, for instance in the Quad, or the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue that informally brings together for strategic talks and military exercises, the US, Japan, Australia and India.

But India, quite aware of the inherent dangers of posturing in the region, has sought to bring its own vision to the definition of Indo-Pacific.

56 The geopolitics of Indo-Pacific

In June 2018, at the Shangri La Dialogue in Singapore, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said: “The Indo-Pacific is a natural region. It is also home to a vast array of global opportunities and challenges... The ten countries of South East Asia connect the two great oceans in both the geographical and civilisational sense. Inclusiveness, openness and ASEAN centrality and unity, therefore, lie at the heart of the new Indo-Pacific. India does not see the Indo-Pacific Region as a strategy or as a club of limited members. Nor as a grouping that seeks to dominate. And by no means do we consider it as directed against any country. A geographical definition, as such, cannot be. India’s vision for the Indo-Pacific Region is, therefore, a positive one.”

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar’s statement, during US Secretary of State Mike Pompeo’s visit to Delhi earlier this week captured some of that caution.

“On the Indo-Pacific, the point — the big point — I made was that the Indo-Pacific is for something, not against somebody. And that something is peace, security, stability, prosperity and rules,” Jaishankar said in his opening remarks at the joint press meet with Pompeo in New Delhi Wednesday.

It is unclear if India and US are on the same page on the definition of the Indo-Pacific. In the last US National Security Strategy document, in 2017, the Indo-Pacific is described as the region from the “west coast of India to the west coast of the United States”. However, India looks at it as a wider region, which extends all the way to West Asia and the east coast of Africa. For India, as important as securing the east, is its western maritime security, where the Indian Ocean and Arabian Sea meet – aside from the hostility with Pakistan, India’s energy sources are all in west Asia, where Delhi’s friendly ties with Tehran US-Iran hostility. Nor does the US definition take into account India’s robust engagement with the Indian Ocean Rim Association countries.

- It refers to the Indian and the Pacific Oceans between the East Coast of Africa and the American West Coast and their several littoral countries.
- The term is in use from around the same time as China's rise.

WHAT DO YOU UNDERSTAND BY INDO-PACIFIC?



The earliest it was noticed was in a paper written by Gurpreet Khurana, an Indian Naval Officer, on the congruence between Japanese and Indian strategic interests in protecting the sea routes for energy security.

THERE ARE DIFFERENCES IN THE DEFINITION OF INDO-PACIFIC

WHAT U.S. SAYS?

In the US National Security Strategy document of 2017, it is mentioned Indo-Pacific as the region from the “West Coast of India to the West Coast of the United States”



WHAT INDIA THINKS?

India thinks it as a wider region, which extends all the way to the West Asia and the East Coast of Africa.



HOW INDO-PACIFIC CONSTRUCT EVOLVED THROUGH THE PRISM OF USA? ... IS IT TO CONTAIN CHINA?

- 1 Western Pacific Ocean and the Indian Ocean came to be considered as **one strategic arc**.
- 2 This is driven by **increased economic interaction** between South, Northeast and Southeast Asia and importance of the lines of energy supply to Asia from the Middle East.
- 3 China is claiming up to **Nine-Dash Line of South China Sea**, much against the wishes of its Asian neighbours.
- 4 In October 2017, in a speech on US-India relations by former US Secretary of State, it was indicated as a partnership between two countries in the interests of a **"Free and Open Indo-Pacific"**.
- 5 It was also mentioned that India is more reliable than China. The idea is the Indo-Pacific should become a place of **peace, stability and growing prosperity**, instead of region of **disorder, conflict and predatory economics**.
- 6 Gradually, it is understood as redefining the region away from China's **economic and strategic dominance**.
- 7 Trump Administration replaced the earlier Asia Pacific with Indo-Pacific.



WHAT IS EXPECTED FROM INDIA BY USA?



Subrahmanyam Jaishankar

Minister of External Affairs of India

On the Indo-Pacific, the External Affairs Minister said it is not against some body, it is for peace, security, stability, prosperity and rule based international order.

- 1 The move away from Asia Pacific towards Indo-Pacific seemed to elevate India to a position of prominence in the region.
- 2 It is with a view to contain China's dominance. It also probes India to play a larger role in the region, for instance in the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue, it is expected to bring informally together the four countries for strategic talks and military exercises.

WHAT THE PRIME MINISTER ENUNCIATED AT THE SHANGRI LA DIALOGUE?



Prime Minister spoke at the Shangri La Dialogue in Singapore.

- 1 The Indo-Pacific is a natural region. It is also home to a vast array of global opportunities and challenges.
- 2 The ten countries of South East Asia connect the two great oceans in both the geographical and civilisational sense.
- 3 Inclusiveness, openness and ASEAN centrality and unity, lie at the heart of the new Indo-Pacific.
- 4 India does not see the Indo-Pacific as a strategy or as a club of limited members.
- 5 It is not a grouping that seeks to dominate, it is not directed against any country.

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